Diagnosing brand health

Brand Audit

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OCTOBER 2026

Learning objectives

By the end of this session you can …

1. Explain what a brand audit is and when a firm should run one.
2. Structure an audit with Keller's brand inventory and brand exploratory.
3. Choose methods to measure brand equity, and justify the choice.
4. Read brand health data critically: size effects, sentiment accuracy, valuations.
5. Plan and run a team brand audit of an Austrian brand.

Why brands need audits

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Part 1 of 5 · Definition, triggers, costs

What a brand audit is

A consumer-focused, comprehensive check of a brand: how healthy it is, where its equity comes from, and how to improve and leverage that equity.

Based on Keller & Swaminathan, Strategic Brand Management, 5th ed., Pearson

Health

How strong is the brand today, against competitors and its own past?

Sources

Which associations, assets and touchpoints create that strength?

Action

What should change in positioning, portfolio and marketing?

When firms run an audit

Strategic shift

New market, new segment or a planned repositioning.

New leadership

A new CMO diagnoses before setting strategy.

Before a rebrand

Know which assets carry equity before changing them.

Portfolio decisions

Keep, merge, migrate or retire brands after M&A.

Crisis

Measure reputational damage by segment and over time.

Regular cadence

Deep audit every few years, a lean tracker in between.

Ritson (Marketing Week, 2023): brand diagnosis is the brand manager's first job.

What skipping the audit can cost

–20 %

Tropicana, 2009: unit sales in under two months after the carton redesign dropped the orange-and-straw.
IRI data via Ad Age/Bloomberg (2009)

1 week

Gap, 2010: life span of the new logo before a backlash forced a return to the blue box.
Pollach, The CASE Journal (2016)

–20 pts

Bud Light, 2023: YouGov Impression, April to June, after a partnership alienated core buyers.
YouGov BrandIndex (31 Aug 2023)

Each case changed brand elements without knowing what carried the equity.

Where an audit looks



Brand inventory

Elements, products, price, communication, distribution

Brand exploratory

Awareness, associations, attitudes, attachment

Market data

Price premium, share, penetration, loyalty

Valuation

Brand value, stock returns

Audit question: do the perceptions we measure move market and financial outcomes?

Sources: Keller & Lehmann (2006), Marketing Science 25(6); Mizik & Jacobson (2008), Journal of Marketing Research 45(1).

The brand audit process

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Part 2 of 5 · Inventory, exploratory, CBBE pyramid

Two parts of every audit

Brand inventory

Supply side: what the firm does

A complete profile of how the brand is marketed.

Elements, portfolio, products, price, communication, distribution.

The same profile for the main competitors.

Output: the intended positioning and its consistency.

Brand exploratory

Demand side: what buyers remember

What consumers know, think and feel about the brand.

Secondary data, then qualitative research, then a survey.

Benchmarked against the same competitors.

Output: sources of equity and gaps to the intended positioning.

The brand inventory checklist

Area	What to collect	Typical sources
Brand elements	Name, logo, colours, pack, slogan, sound	Packs, website, brand book
Portfolio	Brands, sub-brands, endorsements	Annual report, company site
Product	Range, benefits, quality cues	Range lists, reviews
Price	Price points, premium, promotions	Store checks, scanner data
Communication	Campaigns, claims, media mix, social	Ad archives, Effie entries
Distribution	Channels, shelf presence, availability	Store visits, retailer data
Competitors	The same profile for 2–3 rivals	All of the above

Key question: do elements, claims and touchpoints tell one consistent story?

Auditing the brand architecture

One master brand — **Stand-alone brands**

Branded house

A1: more than 10 local brands moved to one brand in 2017; EUR 350m of brand value written off.

Sub-brands

BILLA and BILLA PLUS: the 52-year-old Merkur brand retired into BILLA PLUS in 2021.

Endorsed brands

Rauch: Happy Day and Bravo carry the Rauch umbrella brand and its tree.

House of brands

Josef Manner & Comp.: Manner, Casali, Napoli, Victor Schmidt.

- **Audit question:** does the current position fit industry, company and product drivers?

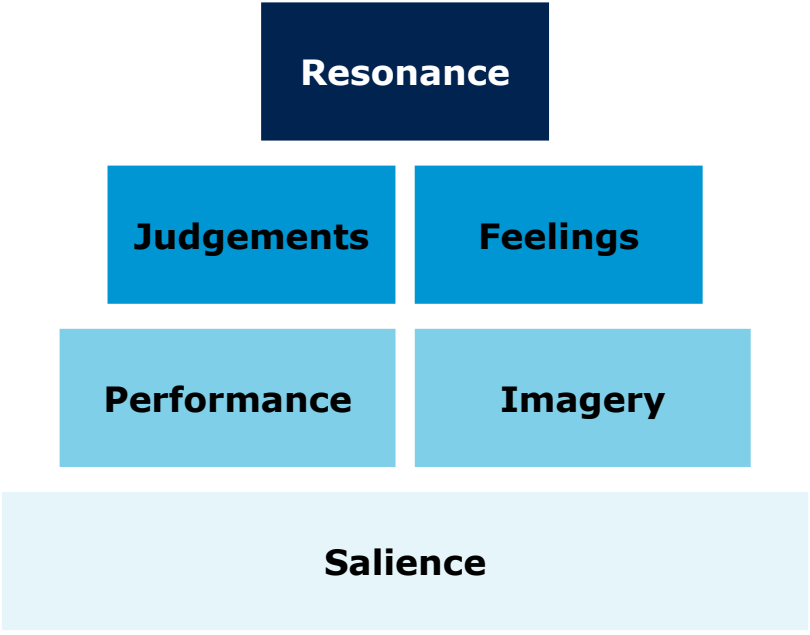
Sources: Aaker & Joachimsthaler (2000), California Management Review; Strebinger (2014), European Journal of Marketing; Leadersnet (2017); REWE Group (2021).

The brand exploratory in three steps

1 Secondary data	2 Qualitative research	3 Survey
Annual reports, trackers, rankings, search trends, earlier studies.	Free association, laddering, ZMET, brand concept maps, projective tasks.	Awareness, brand-attribute grid, equity scales, personality, vs. competitors.

- **Qualitative first:** it gives you the buyers' words for the survey items.
- **Sample:** category buyers, light buyers and non-buyers, not only loyal fans.

The CBBE pyramid as audit structure



Relationships. How loyal, attached and engaged are buyers?

Response. Quality, credibility, consideration; warmth, fun, security?

Meaning. Which associations, and how strong, favourable and unique?

Identity. Does the brand come to mind in buying situations?

Sources: Keller (1993), Journal of Marketing 57(1); Keller (2016), AMS Review 6.

Identity versus image

Identity: inside-out

- What management and employees intend the brand to be.
- Kapferer's prism: physique, personality, culture, relationship, reflection, self-image.
- Data: brand book, interviews, employee survey.

Image: outside-in

- What buyers actually associate with the brand.
- Keller's CBBE: strength, favourability and uniqueness of associations.
- Data: the brand exploratory with buyers and non-buyers.

The core audit finding is the gap between intended identity and perceived image.

Sources: Kapferer, The New Strategic Brand Management; Burmann et al., Identitätsbasierte Markenführung (5th ed., 2024); King, Grace & Funk (2012), JBM.

Measuring brand equity

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Part 3 of 5 · Associations, scales, mental availability, assets, tracking

Methods to uncover associations

Method	What it reveals	Effort	Key source
Free association	Number, valence, uniqueness	Low	Krishnan (1996), IJRM
Concept maps	Association network, consensus map	Medium	John et al. (2006), JMR
Laddering	Attributes, consequences, values	Medium	Reynolds & Gutman (1988)
ZMET	Deep metaphors, hidden meaning	High	Zaltman & Coulter (1995)
Pick-any grid	Brand-attribute links at scale	Low	Driesener & Romaniuk (2006)
Text mining	Associations in reviews and posts	Medium	Netzer et al. (2012)

Choosing: Plumeyer et al. (2019) compare 12 techniques and give a decision roadmap.

Brand equity scales

Scale	Dimensions	Best for
Aaker (1996): Brand Equity Ten	Loyalty, quality and leadership, associations, awareness, market behaviour	Tracker skeleton
Yoo & Donthu (2001)	Loyalty, perceived quality, awareness and associations, overall equity	Cross-brand surveys
Netemeyer et al. (2004)	Quality, value for cost, uniqueness, willingness to pay a premium	Link to price premium
Brakus et al. (2009)	Sensory, affective, intellectual, behavioural experience	Experience module

- Validate with confirmatory factor analysis before comparing brands.
- Survey equity does not always track sales-based equity (Datta, Ailawadi & van Heerde, 2017).

Measuring brand personality

Aaker (1997)

42 items, five dimensions

Sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication, ruggedness.

The classic, widely replicated instrument.

Geuens et al. (2009)

12 items, five factors

Responsibility, activity, aggressiveness, simplicity, emotionality.

Removes non-personality items; tested across brands, categories and countries.

Critique: Azoulay & Kapferer (2003) show that Aaker's scale mixes personality with other identity facets.

Lab: a perceptual map in 20 minutes

The data

Chapman & Feit: 100 respondents rate 10 brands on 9 adjectives (1–10).

Perform, leader, latest, fun, serious, bargain, value, trendy, rebuy.

1,000 rows, simulated teaching data, free CSV.

1. Average the ratings per brand.
2. Run a PCA or correspondence analysis (R FactoMineR, Python prince).
3. Plot brands and adjectives on the first two dimensions.
4. Name the dimensions, find crowded and empty spaces.

Extension: ask an LLM for the same ratings and compare maps (Li et al., 2024: over 75 % agreement).

Mental availability

Caveat first: big brands get more associations on every attribute. Compare observed with expected scores.

Category entry points

Buying situations and needs that cue the category.

Mental penetration

Share of category buyers linking the brand to at least one entry point.

Mental market share

The brand's share of all brand–entry point links in the category.

Network size

Entry points linked, among those who link any.

How to measure: show category buyers about 20 entry points and ask which brands they link to each.

Sources: Romaniuk & Sharp (2003), JTMAM; Romaniuk & Sharp (2004), Marketing Theory; Romaniuk, Better Brand Health (OUP, 2023).

Auditing distinctive brand assets

low fame, high uniqueness **Invest**	high fame, high uniqueness **Use or lose**
low fame, low uniqueness **Ignore or test**	high fame, low uniqueness **Avoid using alone**

Fame: share of category buyers who link the asset to the brand.

Uniqueness: share of those links that go to this brand, not rivals.

Benchmarks: shapes average about 40 % fame and 71 % uniqueness; colours about 12 % and 39 %.

Warning: managers overestimate fame and underestimate uniqueness. Test with buyers.

Sources: Romaniuk, Building Distinctive Brand Assets (2018); Phua et al. (2026), Int. J. of Advertising; Brus et al. (2025), JBM.

From audit to tracker

Deep audit

Every few years, or at a trigger

Full inventory, qualitative and quantitative research.

Finds the few associations that drive choice.

Defines what the tracker will measure.

Brand tracker

Continuous or yearly

Few metrics, same questions and sample over time.

Always against competitors.

Report buyers and non-buyers separately.

Lean it out: 27 common survey brand metrics reduce to a handful of dimensions (Lehmann, Keller & Farley, 2008).

Beyond the survey

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Part 4 of 5 · Online data, AI answers, brand valuation

EFMD EQUIS ACCREDITED AACSB ACCREDITED ASSOCIATION OF MBAS AMBA ACCREDITED

Auditing brands from online data

Study	Data	What it gives the audit
Netzer et al. (2012)	Forum posts	Brand co-mention maps, checked against surveys and sales
Tirunillai & Tellis (2014)	About 350,000 reviews	Quality dimensions and positioning maps over time
Culotta & Cutler (2016)	Twitter followers	Eco, luxury and nutrition perceptions for 200+ brands
Rust et al. (2021)	Twitter text	A weekly brand reputation tracker

- Sentiment tools differ a lot in accuracy: check the method (Hartmann et al., 2023).
- Volume is not representativeness: online voices skew to heavy users and critics.

Bud Light 2023: one crisis, three lenses

53×

Social listening: 1.08m mentions in 11 days after the post, against 20,400 in the 11 days before.
The Social Element via Fox Business (Apr 2023)

−20.2

Brand tracking: YouGov Impression 6.2 to −14; Consideration 14.1 to 10.9.
YouGov BrandIndex, 1 Apr–11 Jun 2023

−21.5

Segments and rivals: Impression among over-50s (18–34: −10.8); Stella Artois only −3.5.
YouGov BrandIndex, 1 Apr–11 Jun 2023

Lesson: listening shows the noise; tracking shows who changed their mind.

The brand in AI answers

Why it matters

Buyers ask ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity which brand to choose.

LLMs reproduce perceptual maps (Li et al., 2024) but fail as respondents in some tasks (Arora et al., 2025).

What to measure

Mentions and position in answers to a fixed prompt set.

Share of voice against rivals, sentiment, cited sources, factual accuracy.

Tools and data

Otterly.AI (Vienna), Peec AI (Berlin), Profound, Semrush, Ahrefs.

Open data: 35,640 LLM answers on 66 European brands in 12 languages (Zenodo, 2026).

Try it: run 10 category prompts for your audit brand and two rivals, three times each, and count mentions.

Putting a value on the brand

Provider	Logic	Consumer input
Interbrand	Economic profit × role of brand × brand strength	Brand strength score
Kantar BrandZ	Financial value × brand contribution	Meaningful, different, salient
Brand Finance	Royalty relief: strength index sets the royalty rate	Brand Strength Index
European Brand Institute	ISO-oriented valuation; Austrian and EU rankings	Market and brand data

ISO 10668 (2010)

Monetary valuation: income, market and cost approaches.

ISO 20671 (2019/2021)

Non-monetary brand evaluation: inputs and outcomes. A ready audit outline.

Red Bull 2026: same brand, two values

Brand Finance Austria 25

€10.6 bn

September 2026, royalty-relief method

European Brand Institute

~€20.1 bn

July 2026, Österreichische Markenwert-Studie

- **Discuss:** why do two ISO-oriented methods differ by about a factor of two?
- **Evidence:** in 2008, consumer-based equity predicted stock returns better than Interbrand values (Johansson et al., 2012).

Applying the audit

Part 5 of 5 · Data, cases, mini audit, team project

Free brand data for Austria

Source	Coverage	Example finding
Marketagent BRAND.Diamonds 2024	237,880 ratings, 1,266 brands	Manner #1 on attraction, 84.5 %
BAV Austria 2025	12,500 people, ~1,000 brands	Manner and Apple lost strength
Brand Finance Austria 25	Brand value, strength index	Top 25 worth EUR 46.8bn (2026)
EBI Markenwert-Studie	180 brand companies, 16 sectors	ÖBB most sustainable brand
Google Trends	Search interest by Bundesland	Share of search by brand

Plus WU library: Statista brand KPIs and journal access. Check the licence for Qualtrics or Unipark before fieldwork.

Cases for discussion

Case	Source	Audit focus
Red Bull Spreads its Wiiings	LBS CS-22-016 (2022)	Extensions, architecture
Swarovski: shine through stormy weather?	IMD-7-2430 (2023)	Brand image, strategy
Zotter: Living by Chocolate	HBS 9-810-091	Founder brand, growth
Barbie: Reviving a Cultural Icon	HBS 525-006 (2024)	Revitalisation
Managing Brand Crisis: Bud Light	Darden M-1043 (2023)	Crisis, core buyers
Rebuild the World (LEGO)	AEF, free with data	Tracking, board report
Brand Report Card Exercise	HBS 501004	Ten-trait scoring

Austrian brands without a teaching case (Manner, ÖBB, SPAR, Raiffeisen) are covered by press and data in the resource guide.

Exercise: a mini audit in 35 minutes

Teams of four, one Austrian brand each: Manner, Almdudler, ÖBB, SPAR, BIPA or Stiegl.

10 min	**Inventory:** brand elements, sub-brands and current claim from website and packs.
5 min	**Free association:** ask five classmates for three words each; code the valence.
5 min	**Assets:** show three assets without the name. Who names the brand?
5 min	**Benchmark:** compare with the Marketagent BRAND.Diamonds charts.
10 min	**Pitch:** one finding and one recommendation, two minutes per team.

Team project: a full brand audit

Report structure

1 Executive summary

2 Brand inventory, with two competitors

3 Exploratory: [__] interviews, survey n ≥ [__]

4 Diagnosis: pyramid, assets, identity–image gap

5 Recommendations and a tracker proposal

Logistics

Teams: [__] students

Brand: Austrian, approved by [date]

Report: [__] pages plus appendix, due [date]

Presentation: [__] minutes on [date]

Weight: [__] % of the final grade

Model answers: Keller's sample audit (Rolex) and the published Lacasa audit, Journal of Brand Strategy.

Toolkit for the project

Survey

LimeSurvey (open source); Unipark or Qualtrics, WU licence to be checked.

Analysis in R

FactoMineR for maps, lavaan for scales, tidytext for text.

Analysis in Python

prince for maps, semopy for scales, BERTopic for topics.

Search and social

Google Trends for share of search; Brand24 trial for mentions.

AI visibility

A fixed prompt set; Otterly.AI or Semrush free checks.

Templates

Smartsheet audit templates, Miro audit board, Baumgarth Markenaudit.

Practice data: Chapman & Feit brand ratings (CSV in the course folder).

Readings

Core

- Keller & Swaminathan, Strategic Brand Management, 5th ed.: brand audit chapter and sample audit.
- Keller (1993), Journal of Marketing 57(1).
- Romaniuk (2023), Better Brand Health, Oxford University Press.
- Baumgarth (2016), Marken-Audit, PraxisWISSEN Marketing (German, free).

Further

- Plumeyer et al. (2019), Review of Managerial Science 13(2).
- Yoo & Donthu (2001), Journal of Business Research 52(1).
- Netzer et al. (2012), Marketing Science 31(3).
- Li et al. (2024), Marketing Science 43(2).
- Romaniuk (2018), Building Distinctive Brand Assets.

Full resource guide with 377 sources: Notion page "Brand Audit" in Literature Search for Teaching.

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Next steps

Teams: form your team and choose an Austrian brand for the project.

Reading: Keller's brand audit chapter and Romaniuk, Better Brand Health.

Questions? Book a slot in my office hours.